

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 3

Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	8 — How the Land Becomes Sacred
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Sacredness in India is not limited to buildings — journeys, rivers, mountains, forests, trees and the whole land can be sacred; pilgrimage and trade routes usually overlapped rather than staying separate; and many holy sites are shared across faiths. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A traveller crosses the country visiting Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram in a single long journey. Which idea from the chapter does this journey BEST illustrate?

- (A) That sacredness in India is confined to a single northern valley
- (B) That each of these shrines is sacred only to people of its own region
- (C) That pilgrimage was permitted only to kings who could afford the distance
- (D) That networks of holy sites stitch distant corners of the subcontinent into one connected sacred landscape

2. Why does the chapter treat the word 'tirtha' — rooted in a word for a river-crossing — as a clue to how Indians imagined holiness?

- (A) Because it proves every sacred site must literally lie on a riverbank
- (B) Because it shows holy places were named only after the rivers near them
- (C) Because it means a tirtha can be reached only by boat
- (D) Because it frames a sacred place as a point where one crosses from ordinary life toward a higher, spiritual life

3. A student claims, 'Only religions born in India have sacred sites here.' The best correction is that:

- (A) Only Hinduism, the oldest faith, has true sacred sites in India
- (B) Almost every religion in India, whether it arose here or came from outside, marks its own sacred places across the land
- (C) Sacred sites here belong only to faiths that arrived from outside India
- (D) No religion can claim a sacred place unless the government recognises it

4. Sufi dargahs in India are often visited by Hindus, Muslims and others alike. This is offered in the chapter mainly as evidence that:

- (A) Dargahs were originally Hindu temples that changed hands
- (B) Each sacred site in India serves exactly one religion
- (C) Pilgrimage in India is a recent custom copied from abroad
- (D) Many of India's holy places are shared and revered across several faiths and communities

5. Many revered shrines sit atop hard-to-climb hills. The chapter reads the difficulty of the climb as:

- (A) A sign that the deity wishes to keep visitors away
- (B) Proof that only the physically strongest deserve to worship
- (C) A mirror of the inner effort of spiritual growth that the pilgrim undertakes
- (D) An accidental hardship with no deeper meaning

6. In Jainism the title 'Tirthankara' literally means 'one who makes a tirtha (crossing/ford)'. This shared root with 'tirtha' best shows that across Indian faiths sacredness is tied to the idea of:

- (A) Crossing from ordinary existence to a higher, liberated, spiritual life
- (B) Building the tallest possible shrine to display devotion
- (C) Granting tax-free land to holy teachers
- (D) Winning protection through a king's military victory

7. Which statement about India's sacred networks gives the CORRECT numbers?

- (A) The char dham are 12, the jyotirlingas 4, and the Shakti pithas 51
- (B) The char dham are 4, the jyotirlingas 51, and the Shakti pithas 12
- (C) The char dham are 51, the jyotirlingas 12, and the Shakti pithas 4
- (D) The char dham are 4, the jyotirlingas 12, and the Shakti pithas traditionally 51

8. By tradition the Shakti pithas mark places where parts of the divine mother (Sati) are said to have fallen, scattered across the subcontinent. The chief cultural effect of such a scattering was to:

- (A) Keep each region's worship sealed off from every other
- (B) Limit goddess worship to a single city in the north
- (C) Replace all river worship with shrine worship
- (D) Bind far-apart regions together into one shared sacred landscape of the goddess

9. Pilgrims travelling for weeks between distant sacred sites needed food, supplies and lodging along the way. The chapter uses this to explain why:

- (A) Pilgrims were forbidden to carry money on the journey
- (B) Traders were banned from approaching any sacred site
- (C) Pilgrimage routes and trade routes frequently overlapped, carrying both devotion and goods
- (D) Pilgrimage and trade always followed completely separate roads

10. A sangam — the meeting point of two or more rivers — is regarded as especially sacred because:

- (A) The rivers stop flowing there forever, making the water holy
- (B) Bathing is strictly forbidden there, which adds to its mystery
- (C) It marks the tax boundary between two kingdoms
- (D) As a place where waters cross and join, it fits the deep idea of a tirtha, a crossing point

11. The Kumbh Mela does NOT recur at the same place every year. It actually:

- (A) Moves to a different country each year following the monsoon
- (B) Is held once every thousand years at a single fixed city
- (C) Rotates among Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain on a roughly twelve-year cycle set by the positions of Jupiter and the Sun
- (D) Occurs annually at Prayagraj and nowhere else

12. The name 'Kumbh Mela' combines 'kumbh' and 'mela'. The pairing recalls:

- (A) A 'mountain' and a 'river' that meet at the fair
- (B) A 'pot' and a 'fair/gathering' — echoing the pot of amrita (nectar) of legend
- (C) A 'king' and the 'temple' he built beside the Ganga
- (D) A 'tree' and the 'grove' protected around it

13. Sacred mountains are often described in the chapter as 'gateways to heaven'. This description best illustrates how, in India:

- (A) Only flat plains, never mountains, can be considered sacred
- (B) Geography and religion are deliberately kept apart from each other
- (C) Geography, culture and spirituality fuse so that a physical landform carries religious meaning
- (D) Mountains are regarded as worthless rock with no human value

14. The Bodhi tree, under which the Buddha is said to have attained enlightenment, was a peepal. This is one example the chapter uses to argue that:

- (A) Sacredness in India is limited to temples and other buildings
- (B) Only fig trees, and no other part of Nature, can ever be holy

- (C) Trees themselves can be sacred, so holiness reaches beyond built shrines into living Nature
- (D) The Buddha forbade his followers from revering any natural place

15. The banyan tree's English name is traced to the 'banias' (traders) who gathered in its broad shade. This small fact best supports the broader point that:

- (A) Traders were strictly forbidden from resting near sacred trees
- (B) The banyan was sacred only to traders and to no one else
- (C) Trees were named only after the kings who planted them
- (D) Economic life and sacred or cultural life were closely intertwined in India

16. In a sacred grove the community forbids hunting, felling trees and mining. The chapter explains this prohibition as resting mainly on:

- (A) Strict government laws backed by regular police patrols
- (B) High walls and locked gates that physically bar entry
- (C) The belief that the grove is a deity's dwelling, so harming it would disrespect the divine
- (D) Annual payments the king makes to the villagers

17. Sacred groves have often preserved rich biodiversity and water sources for centuries. This is presented as evidence that:

- (A) Conservation only ever works when enforced by the police
- (B) Belief can conserve Nature effectively even without formal legal protection
- (C) Religious belief always damages the natural environment
- (D) Forests can be protected only inside city limits

18. The great epics, the chapter notes, link many places across India to the journeys and deeds of their heroes. The cultural result of this was that:

- (A) Only a single holy place in all of India was recognised
- (B) Sacred sites became scattered all over the land, knitting distant regions into a shared story
- (C) Pilgrimage to any of these places was forbidden
- (D) The epics described no real places at all

19. Assertion (A): Treating the whole land as sacred has helped conserve Nature in India.

Reason (R): When rivers, mountains and forests are seen as holy, people gain a strong motive to protect them. Choose the best evaluation.

- (A) Both A and R are true, and R correctly explains A
- (B) Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A
- (C) A is true but R is false
- (D) A is false but R is true

20. Which choice BEST captures a 'punyakshetra', where geography, culture and spirituality fuse?

- (A) A coin minted to advertise a king's power
- (B) A riverbank or forest revered as holy, where pilgrims gather and Nature is protected
- (C) A copper plate recording a tax-free land grant
- (D) A court poet's inscription praising a ruler

21. A claim states: 'Sacred geography of this kind is found only in India.' The chapter would judge this:

- (A) Mistaken, because reverence for sacred landscapes is found in other parts of the world too
- (B) Correct, because no other country has any holy places
- (C) Correct, because sacred geography was invented in modern Europe
- (D) Mistaken, because India in fact has no sacred geography

22. Why does the chapter say sacred geography helped 'integrate' the subcontinent rather than divide it?

- (A) Because everyone was forced to adopt a single common language
- (B) Because each region was sealed off and kept entirely to itself
- (C) Because all regional kingdoms were abolished to make one state
- (D) Because pilgrims moving between far-flung sites carried ideas, stories and customs across regions

23. Rivers and their confluences have been worshipped in India since:

- (A) Only the last hundred years, as a modern movement
- (B) Only after the fall of the Gupta empire
- (C) At least Vedic times, making river reverence very ancient
- (D) Only in the era of large modern cities

24. A 'relic' kept at a shrine is best described as:

- (A) The confluence where two sacred rivers meet
- (B) A part of a holy figure's body, or one of their belongings, preserved as an object of reverence
- (C) A counted era used to date inscriptions
- (D) A tax-free village granted to a temple

25. Which set correctly names the four char dham that ring India?

- (A) Badrinath (north), Dwarka (west), Puri (east) and Rameswaram (south)
- (B) Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain
- (C) Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagar and Lumbini
- (D) Badrinath, Kanchipuram, Madurai and Dwarka

26. The jyotirlingas form a network of how many shrines, and to which deity?

- (A) Fifty-one shrines dedicated to the goddess
- (B) Twelve shrines, all dedicated to Shiva
- (C) Four shrines dedicated to Vishnu
- (D) Seven shrines dedicated to the Buddha

27. Which best explains why busy pilgrimage routes naturally turned into trading routes too?

- (A) Large numbers of travelling pilgrims created steady demand for food, supplies and lodging that traders supplied
- (B) Sacred sites paid traders specifically to stay far away
- (C) Pilgrims were required by custom to carry no possessions
- (D) Trade was outlawed everywhere except inside temples

28. A student argues that 'sacredness ends at a temple's walls.' The chapter's strongest counter is that:

- (A) There is exactly one holy building in all of India
- (B) Only foreigners regard India's open land as holy
- (C) Sacred places exist only for a single year before losing their status
- (D) Revered rivers, mountains, forests, trees and pilgrim routes show holiness spreading across the whole land

29. Why does the chapter call the difficult climb to a hilltop shrine 'meaningful' rather than merely inconvenient?

- (A) Because the fastest route to any shrine is always the most sacred
- (B) Because the effort of the outer journey is felt to reflect the effort of inner spiritual growth
- (C) Because it proves which pilgrim is physically the strongest
- (D) Because it lets pilgrims avoid all contact with Nature

30. Across Hindu, Buddhist and Jain traditions the word 'tirtha' or its relatives recur. The deepest shared meaning the chapter draws from this is that sacredness is widely understood as:

- (A) The amount of land a temple owns
- (B) The military strength of the kingdom that protects it
- (C) The age in years of the oldest shrine in a region
- (D) A crossing from the ordinary world toward a higher, liberated state

31. Treating a forest grove as the home of a deity does double duty in the chapter's argument because it:

- (A) Turns the forest into government property that police must guard
- (B) Encourages villagers to mine and log it for quick income
- (C) Expresses reverence for Nature and, at the same time, conserves a living ecosystem
- (D) Proves that only buildings, not forests, can ever be sacred

32. Which pairing of the two largest networks gives the right counts?

- (A) Jyotirlingas number 51 and Shakti pithas number 12
- (B) Jyotirlingas number 4 and Shakti pithas number 12

(C) Jyotirlingas number 12 and Shakti pithas number 51

(D) Jyotirlingas number 51 and Shakti pithas number 4

33. The chapter says sacred geography helped knit India together 'for at least three thousand years.' This long span is meant to show that the integrating force was:

(A) A brief modern campaign limited to recent decades

(B) Active only during the rule of one particular dynasty

(C) Something that operated for a single century and then stopped

(D) Deep and continuous, shaping the civilisation over a vast stretch of time

34. Which example BEST shows that a single sacred place can matter to more than one religious tradition?

(A) A temple that admits worshippers of only its own sect

(B) A site such as Bodh Gaya or a Sufi dargah honoured by people of different faiths

(C) A royal palace open exclusively to the king's family

(D) A market square used solely for buying and selling

35. The peepal (*Ficus religiosa*) is revered across several Indian faiths. The best reason the chapter offers for highlighting such a tree is to show that:

(A) Only the peepal among all trees has ever been considered holy

(B) Living elements of Nature, not only built structures, can be objects of shared reverence

(C) Trees are sacred only to the faith that first revered them

(D) Reverence for Nature is found exclusively in one religion

36. The banyan (*Ficus benghalensis*) is distinctive among trees because its:

(A) Hanging aerial roots grow downward and harden into new trunks, so one tree spreads widely

(B) Leaves turn to gold once every spring

(C) Trunk is naturally made of stone

(D) Flowers bloom only during the Kumbh Mela

37. 'Conservation', as the chapter ties it to sacred places, means:

(A) Protecting and keeping Nature, biodiversity or heritage safe for the future

(B) Clearing forests quickly for the largest possible profit

(C) Building over rivers and confluences to expand cities

(D) Discarding old traditions in favour of new constructions

38. Assertion (A): Many pilgrimage centres grew into busy market towns. Reason (R): Pilgrims passing through needed goods and services, so traders settled along the routes. Choose the best evaluation.

(A) Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A

(B) Both A and R are true, and R correctly explains A

(C) A is true but R is false

(D) A is false but R is true

39. A 'shrine' is regarded as holy chiefly because of its association with:

- (A) The divine, a sacred relic, or a revered spiritual figure
- (B) A famous battle and nothing more
- (C) A royal palace and nothing more
- (D) A busy market town and nothing more

40. The phrase 'sacred geography' is best understood to mean that:

- (A) Only one mountain in the entire country counts as holy
- (B) Geography lessons must be taught inside temple grounds
- (C) Holy places are spread across the territory so that the land itself comes to feel sacred
- (D) India keeps no record or map of where its holy sites lie

41. Which best explains how a faith that arrived from outside India came to have deeply revered sites within the country?

- (A) Outside faiths were each given a single site by royal decree and no more
- (B) Such faiths simply renamed existing temples without changing anything
- (C) Only the government could grant an outside faith any sacred place
- (D) Over centuries its followers settled, built and honoured holy places here, weaving them into India's sacred geography

42. Why does the chapter present sacred mountains as 'gateways to heaven' rather than as ordinary peaks?

- (A) Because mountains physically touch the sky and so are scientifically holy
- (B) Because only people living abroad are allowed to climb them
- (C) Because mountains mark the borders no traveller may cross
- (D) Because the imagination links the height of the mountain with the ascent toward the divine

43. Sacred groves survive because harming them is felt to offend a deity. The best general lesson the chapter draws is that:

- (A) Environmental protection is impossible without modern technology
- (B) Cultural belief can be a powerful tool for protecting the environment
- (C) Belief and conservation are opposing forces that cannot coexist
- (D) Only urban authorities can ever safeguard a forest

44. Across India, river confluences, hilltop shrines and ocean-edge temples are all called tirthas. The unifying reason is that each is imagined as a:

- (A) Place where rivers physically begin their flow
- (B) Boundary stone marking the edge of a kingdom
- (C) Crossing point between the ordinary world and a higher, sacred realm
- (D) Site reserved only for royal ceremonies

- 45.** A historian notes that maps of medieval pilgrimage routes and maps of major trade routes look remarkably similar. The best explanation is that:
- (A) The same well-travelled roads served both pilgrims and traders, so the routes overlapped
 - (B) Pilgrims and traders deliberately avoided each other's roads
 - (C) Trade routes were always built centuries after pilgrimage ended
 - (D) The similarity is a coincidence with no real connection
- 46.** Which statement about the duty to protect sacred places today follows MOST directly from the chapter?
- (A) They are useless relics of the past best left to decay
 - (B) Sacred places are a shared heritage of Nature and culture, so protecting them is worthwhile for everyone
 - (C) They matter only for the tourism income they bring
 - (D) They are the private property of traders alone
- 47.** Why does the chapter say a difficult, far-flung set of holy sites actually helped UNIFY rather than fragment India?
- (A) Because the distances kept every region permanently apart
 - (B) Because only one site was ever truly visited
 - (C) Because reaching them meant long journeys that mixed people, languages and customs across regions
 - (D) Because travel between regions was forbidden to ordinary people
- 48.** The chapter's central new claim about sacredness in India is that it:
- (A) Extends beyond buildings to journeys, rivers, mountains, forests, trees and even the whole land
 - (B) Applies only to temples and mosques
 - (C) Belongs only to the single oldest religion
 - (D) Can exist only inside the boundaries of cities
- 49.** Pilgrims at the Kumbh Mela bathe at the river or its sangam. Linking the festival to a confluence reinforces which earlier idea?
- (A) That the festival has no connection to rivers at all
 - (B) That confluences are avoided because bathing is forbidden there
 - (C) That a sangam is a sacred crossing place fitting the tirtha idea, drawing huge gatherings
 - (D) That the Kumbh is held on a hilltop far from any water
- 50.** Which best shows that, in India, geography and spirituality 'fuse together'?
- (A) A temple is built and the surrounding landscape is then ignored
 - (B) Worship happens only indoors, away from any natural feature

(C) A mountain or river is itself worshipped as divine, not merely as a backdrop to worship

(D) Natural features are valued purely for farming and never for faith

51. A student says, 'Sacred groves are protected by strict government laws.' The most accurate response is that this is:

(A) Completely correct, since belief plays no role at all

(B) Largely mistaken — groves are protected mainly by community belief, not by law

(C) Correct, because such groves are not really protected in any way

(D) Mistaken, because sacred groves do not actually exist

52. The Sanskrit word 'tirtha' literally means a:

(A) Place to cross a river — and, by extension, a crossing from ordinary to higher life

(B) Mountain peak that reaches the sky (C) Pot that holds nectar

(D) Grove protected by a village

53. Which set of religions ORIGINATED in India?

(A) Islam, Christianity, Judaism and Zoroastrianism

(B) Christianity, Sikhism, Judaism and Islam

(C) Zoroastrianism, Hinduism, Islam and Buddhism

(D) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism

54. Why does scattering the jyotirlingas and Shakti pithas right across the subcontinent matter for the chapter's main argument?

(A) Because it keeps each region's worship completely isolated

(B) Because it confines all worship to a single chosen city

(C) Because the deliberate spread ties distant regions together into one shared sacred landscape

(D) Because it ends the practice of pilgrimage altogether

55. A Tirthankara in Jainism is best described as:

(A) A supreme teacher of dharma — literally 'one who makes a tirtha (crossing)'

(B) A river formed by two streams meeting

(C) A king who grants tax-free land to teachers

(D) A giant fig tree revered by a community

56. The big idea 'how the land becomes sacred' is best summed up as:

(A) Through pilgrimage, networks of sites and revered Nature, the whole land — not just shrines — comes to be seen as holy

(B) Only a single temple in India is truly holy

(C) Land becomes sacred only when a king formally declares it so

(D) Sacredness has nothing to do with geography at all

57. Why would a single famous shrine often sit at the junction of several pilgrimage routes AND trade routes?

- (A) Because shrines were forbidden anywhere except at empty crossroads
- (B) Because traders were paid to keep all routes apart from shrines
- (C) Because pilgrims and traders were never allowed to meet
- (D) Because the constant flow of pilgrims and traders made such junctions naturally busy and important

58. Which conclusion about India's sacred geography is BEST supported by the whole chapter?

- (A) It mattered only to traders seeking profit
- (B) It blends faith, Nature and movement across the land into a force that long unified a diverse subcontinent
- (C) It divided India permanently into hostile faiths
- (D) It existed only in modern times and not before

59. A student writes: 'In India you don't only visit the sacred — you can travel through a sacred land.' The strongest support from the chapter is that:

- (A) Networks of holy sites together with revered rivers, mountains and forests turn the whole territory into a sacred geography
- (B) There is exactly one holy building in the entire country
- (C) Sacredness ends precisely at a temple's outer walls
- (D) Only foreigners regard India's open land as holy

60. Why does the chapter describe natural places such as rivers, mountains and groves as sacred 'across many religions and communities' rather than to just one faith?

- (A) Because people of different faiths in the same region have come to share reverence for the same natural features
- (B) Because the government assigns each natural feature to one religion at a time
- (C) Because only the oldest religion is permitted to revere Nature
- (D) Because such reverence lasts only for a single year before being reassigned

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred — Paper 3

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	D	11	C	21	A	31	C	41	D	51	B
2	D	12	B	22	D	32	C	42	D	52	A
3	B	13	C	23	C	33	D	43	B	53	D
4	D	14	C	24	B	34	B	44	C	54	C
5	C	15	D	25	A	35	B	45	A	55	A
6	A	16	C	26	B	36	A	46	B	56	A
7	D	17	B	27	A	37	A	47	C	57	D
8	D	18	B	28	D	38	B	48	A	58	B
9	C	19	A	29	B	39	A	49	C	59	A
10	D	20	B	30	D	40	C	50	C	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (D) The four char dham deliberately ring India at its north, west, east and south, so a journey linking them ties far-apart regions into one sacred geography. They are scattered across the country, not packed into one valley. Such sites drew pilgrims from everywhere, not only their home region, and pilgrimage was an ordinary devotional act open to common people, not a royal privilege.

2. (D) The 'crossing' sense turns a tirtha into a symbolic passage from the everyday to the divine, which is why the word fits mountains and shrines as well as river fords. It does not require an actual river — hilltop and inland tirthas exist. The name reflects an idea of spiritual crossing, not a rule about naming sites after rivers, and certainly not a need for a boat.

3. (B) Faiths that originated in India (Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism) and those that came from outside (such as Islam and Christianity) all mark holy places here, so the

claim is wrong both ways. It is not limited to the oldest faith, nor only to outside faiths, and sacredness rests on belief and tradition rather than government recognition.

4. (D) Shared veneration at dargahs shows that sacred sites frequently cross religious lines, which is the point being made. The example is about sharing, not about a site changing religions; it directly contradicts the 'one site, one religion' idea; and pilgrimage in India is an ancient, continuous tradition, not a modern import.

5. (C) The outer hardship of the journey is meant to reflect the inner, spiritual effort of the pilgrim, giving the climb its meaning. It is not a barrier to keep people out, not a test of mere physical strength, and not a meaningless accident — the difficulty is itself part of the symbolism.

6. (A) Both words turn on 'crossing', so a Tirthankara is one who shows the way across to liberation — sacredness as spiritual passage. The common thread is the crossing idea, not the height of buildings, not land grants, and not military or royal power.

7. (D) Char means 'four', so the dham are 4; the jyotirlingas of Shiva number 12; the Shakti pithas number 51 by tradition. The other sets swap these counts, but 'char' fixes the dham at four, and the 12-and-51 pairing for jyotirlingas and pithas is the one to remember.

8. (D) Spreading 51 pithas everywhere meant devotees everywhere shared one connected geography, knitting regions together. It did the opposite of sealing regions off, was not confined to one city, and did not displace the worship of rivers, which continued alongside it.

9. (C) Steady streams of pilgrims created demand that traders met, so the same roads served both, and religious and economic life wove together. This contradicts the idea of moneyless pilgrims, of traders barred from holy sites, and of strictly separate routes — the chapter's point is precisely the overlap.

10. (D) A confluence is literally a crossing-and-joining of waters, matching the tirtha idea of a sacred crossing, which is why it is so revered. Rivers do not stop flowing at a sangam; bathing there is encouraged, not banned; and its sanctity has nothing to do with tax borders.

11. (C) It cycles through four river cities, timed by astronomical positions over about twelve years, so it is neither yearly at one place nor abroad. It does not skip a thousand years, and it is not fixed to Prayagraj alone — all four cities take their turn on the sky-based schedule.

12. (B) 'Kumbh' means pot and 'mela' means a fair or gathering, with the pot recalling the legendary vessel of nectar. The name has nothing to do with a mountain-and-river pair, a king-and-temple pair, or a tree-and-grove pair.

- 13. (C)** Calling a mountain a gateway to heaven shows land and faith merging — the landform itself becomes spiritually charged. This contradicts the notion that only flat land is sacred, that geography and religion stay separate, and that mountains are valueless rock.
- 14. (C)** A revered tree shows sacredness spilling beyond buildings into Nature itself. It refutes the 'buildings only' idea; it is an example, not a claim that fig trees alone among all Nature are holy (rivers, mountains and groves are too); and it does not involve any ban on revering Nature.
- 15. (D)** Traders gathering under a revered tree shows commerce and culture mingling, echoing the pilgrimage-and-trade overlap. It does not show traders banned from sacred trees, the banyan being sacred is not limited to traders, and the naming came from traders, not kings.
- 16. (C)** Sacred groves are guarded chiefly by community belief that the grove houses a deity, making harm a sacrilege. They are not primarily protected by state law and police, nor by walls and gates, nor by royal payments — belief does the protecting.
- 17. (B)** Long-surviving groves show belief alone can safeguard biodiversity and water without statutes — that is the lesson. It contradicts the claims that conservation needs police, that belief harms Nature, and that forests can survive only in cities.
- 18. (B)** By tying heroes' deeds to many locations, the epics seeded holy spots everywhere and bound regions through a common narrative. They did not concentrate holiness in one place, did not forbid pilgrimage, and did name many real places.
- 19. (A)** Seeing Nature as sacred gives people a powerful reason to safeguard it, so the reverence drives the conservation — R genuinely explains A, and both are true. It is not a case of an unrelated true reason, nor is either statement false; the causal link is exactly what the chapter argues.
- 20. (B)** A revered riverbank or forest that draws pilgrims and shelters Nature shows land, culture and spirit merging — the essence of a punyakshetra. A coin, a land-grant plate and a praise-inscription are political or economic records, not fusions of geography with the sacred.
- 21. (A)** The chapter notes sacred geography exists elsewhere as well, so claiming India is unique in this is wrong. Other countries do have holy places; the idea was not a modern European invention; and India clearly does possess a rich sacred geography — so the only error is the word 'only'.
- 22. (D)** Pilgrims crisscrossing the land spread shared stories and customs, weaving diverse regions into one civilisation. Integration came through movement and shared sacredness, not through forced language uniformity, regional isolation, or the abolition of kingdoms.

- 23. (C)** River and confluence worship reaches back at least to Vedic times, so it is among the oldest of practices. It is not a recent or modern-city phenomenon, and it long predates rather than follows the Guptas.
- 24. (B)** A relic is a bodily remain or possession of a revered figure, honoured at a shrine. It is not a river confluence (that is a sangam), not a dating era, and not a land grant — those are different concepts entirely.
- 25. (A)** The classic char dham are Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram, set at the four cardinal edges of the land. Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain are the Kumbh cities; Bodh Gaya, Sarnath and the like are Buddhist sites; and the fourth set mixes in cities that are not part of the standard char dham.
- 26. (B)** The jyotirlingas are 12 and belong to Shiva. The number 51 with the goddess describes the Shakti pithas; four with Vishnu suggests the char dham; and the Buddha is not the focus of any such 'linga' network.
- 27. (A)** Crowds of pilgrims meant constant demand, which traders met, so devotion and commerce shared the same roads. Sites did not pay traders to leave; pilgrims did carry goods and money; and trade was not banned outside temples — the demand simply drew commerce in.
- 28. (D)** Sacred rivers, peaks, groves, trees and journeys all lie outside any building, so holiness clearly extends beyond temple walls. India has many holy places, not one; reverence comes from Indians themselves; and sacred status is enduring, not a one-year affair.
- 29. (B)** The hardship is read as a symbol of inner striving, which gives it meaning. It is not about speed (the hard climb is slower), not a contest of strength, and not a way to avoid Nature — pilgrims pass through it.
- 30. (D)** The recurring 'crossing' root unites these faiths around the idea of passing from ordinary to higher life. It is not about temple landholdings, kingdom strength, or the age of shrines — the common thread is spiritual crossing.
- 31. (C)** A grove seen as a deity's home is both an act of reverence and a means of conservation — belief and biodiversity reinforcing each other. It does not make the grove state property guarded by police, it forbids rather than encourages logging and mining, and it shows forests can indeed be sacred.
- 32. (C)** Shiva's jyotirlingas are 12 and the goddess's Shakti pithas are 51. The other pairings swap or shrink these figures; the reliable memory is 12 lingas and 51 pithas.
- 33. (D)** Three thousand years signals a deep, continuous influence on the civilisation, not a passing event. It rules out the idea of a modern campaign, a single-dynasty episode, or a

one-century burst — the integration has been long and sustained.

34. (B) Shared sites like dargahs, drawing devotees of several faiths, directly show multi-faith sacredness. A single-sect temple is the opposite case, a palace is not a sacred shared site, and a market is a commercial space, not a holy one revered across faiths.

35. (B) A widely revered tree shows Nature itself being held sacred, beyond buildings, and across faiths. It is not a claim that only the peepal is holy (the banyan and others count too), the reverence is shared rather than exclusive to one faith's origin, and it spans multiple religions.

36. (A) The banyan's hanging roots descend and become new trunks, letting a single tree cover a large area and shelter gatherings. Its leaves do not turn gold, its trunk is wood not stone, and its flowering has no link to the Kumbh.

37. (A) Conservation is safeguarding Nature and heritage for the future, which is exactly what sacred-place reverence achieves. It is the opposite of clearing forests for profit, building over rivers, or discarding tradition.

38. (B) Crowds of pilgrims drew traders who served their needs, so towns grew up around the sites — R explains A, and both hold. It is not an unrelated reason, and neither statement is false; the overlap of pilgrimage and trade is the engine described.

39. (A) A shrine's holiness comes from its tie to the divine, a relic, or a holy person. Battles, palaces and markets are political, royal or commercial associations, not what makes a place a shrine.

40. (C) Sacred geography means holiness distributed across the land until the whole territory feels sacred. It is not about a single holy mountain, not about where geography is taught, and not a claim that holy sites go unmapped.

41. (D) Communities of incoming faiths put down roots and established their own honoured sites, which became part of India's sacred landscape. It was not a one-site royal allotment, not mere renaming of temples, and not dependent on government grants — it grew through settlement and devotion.

42. (D) A mountain's height is read symbolically as a rise toward the divine, making it a gateway to heaven. This is a spiritual image, not a scientific claim about touching the sky, not a rule about foreign climbers, and not a statement about closed borders.

43. (B) Belief that protects groves shows culture and conservation working together effectively. It contradicts the claims that technology is essential, that belief and conservation conflict, and that only city authorities can protect forests.

44. (C) What unites these varied places is the shared idea of a sacred crossing from the ordinary to the higher. It is not about river sources, kingdom boundaries, or royal-only use — the common thread is the symbolic crossing.

45. (A) Pilgrims and traders used the same roads because pilgrim crowds drew commerce, so the maps coincide for a real reason. They did not avoid each other, trade did not wait until pilgrimage ended, and the match is not mere coincidence — it reflects a genuine overlap.

46. (B) Seeing sacred sites as a shared natural and cultural heritage makes their protection a common responsibility. They are not useless relics, not valued only for tourist money, and not the property of any single group.

47. (C) Long pilgrimages forced contact and exchange among people from many regions, weaving them together. Distance did not isolate regions here; more than one site was visited; and ordinary people did undertake these journeys — the mixing produced unity.

48. (A) The key idea is that sacredness reaches far past buildings into Nature, journeys and the land itself. It is not limited to temples and mosques, not to one religion, and not to cities — the whole landscape can be holy.

49. (C) The Kumbh gathers at sacred river sites and confluences, reinforcing the sangam-as-tirtha idea. It is deeply tied to rivers, bathing is central rather than forbidden, and it is a riverbank fair, not a hilltop event.

50. (C) When the land feature itself is treated as divine, geography and spirituality have truly merged. Ignoring the landscape, worshipping only indoors, or valuing Nature solely for farming would all keep geography and faith apart.

51. (B) Community belief, not government law, is the main protector of sacred groves, so the claim is largely wrong. Belief plays the central role; the groves are genuinely protected; and they certainly do exist.

52. (A) Tirtha literally means a ford or crossing place, which becomes a symbol of crossing toward the divine. It does not mean a peak, a nectar-pot (that echoes 'kumbh'), or a grove.

53. (D) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism all arose within India. The other sets mix in faiths that came from outside, such as Islam, Christianity, Judaism and Zoroastrianism, so they are not all India-born.

54. (C) Spreading these networks everywhere means devotees everywhere share one connected geography, supporting the unity theme. It does not isolate regions, confine worship to one city, or end pilgrimage — the spread does the opposite.

55. (A) A Tirthankara is a great Jain teacher who 'makes a crossing' to liberation. It is not a river, a land-granting king, or a tree — the title is about spiritual crossing.

56. (A) The land becomes sacred through pilgrim journeys, networks and revered Nature, so the whole territory feels holy. It is not limited to one temple, does not require a royal declaration, and is intimately bound up with geography rather than separate from it.

57. (D) Junctions drew both pilgrims and traders, so a shrine there sat amid heavy, overlapping traffic. Shrines were not restricted to empty crossroads, traders were not paid to avoid them, and pilgrims and traders did share the roads.

58. (B) The chapter ties faith, Nature and pilgrim movement into a unifying force across millennia. It was not merely a traders' concern, did not divide India into hostile camps, and is ancient rather than modern.

59. (A) Because site networks plus sacred Nature spread holiness across the land, one truly travels through a sacred geography. India has many holy places, not one building; sacredness extends well beyond temple walls; and the reverence is held by Indians themselves.

60. (A) Communities of varied faiths living together have often come to honour the same river, hill or grove, so the reverence is shared rather than the property of one faith. It is not parcelled out by the government, not reserved for the oldest religion, and not a temporary yearly grant.